“Fear of hell is the main reason to follow God.”

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Where it often comes from

Coming to faith mainly through frightening sermons about hell. Teaching that used fear to motivate obedience. Following God out of fear without ever experiencing His love. Seeing God mainly as a judge to avoid. Worry that without fear, you would stop obeying.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest about judgment, and a healthy reverence for God is good. But the main reason to follow God is His love. There is no fear in love; perfect love drives out fear. We love because He first loved us. It is God’s kindness that leads us to repentance. Christ’s love compels us. You did not receive a spirit of slavery that leads to fear, but the Spirit of sonship, by whom we cry, “Abba! Father!”

> *“There is no fear in love, but perfect love drives out fear, because fear involves punishment. The one who fears has not been perfected in love. We love because He first loved us”* **(1 John 4:18–19)**.

Also see

> “Or do you disregard the riches of His kindness, tolerance, and patience, not realizing that God’s kindness leads you to repentance?” **(Romans 2:4)**.

> “For Christ’s love compels us, because we are convinced that One died for all, therefore all died” **(2 Corinthians 5:14)**.

> “For you did not receive a spirit of slavery that returns you to fear, but you received the Spirit of sonship, by whom we cry, ‘Abba! Father!’” **(Romans 8:15)**.

> “As the Father has loved Me, so have I loved you. Remain in My love. If you keep My commandments, you will remain in My love, just as I have kept My Father’s commandments and remain in His love. I have told you these things so that My joy may be in you and your joy may be complete” **(John 15:9–11)**.

Common self-statements

- I follow God so I don’t go to hell.
- If I weren’t afraid, I’d stop obeying.
- God is mainly someone to avoid angering.
- Love is nice, but fear is what keeps me in line.
- I don’t really enjoy God; I just fear Him.
- Fear is the only thing that works for me.

Common logical errors

- **Mental filter:** Focusing on judgment while overlooking God’s love.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Believing fear is the strongest motivator for obedience.
- **Projection:** Seeing God as a harsh authority figure.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Thinking that without fear, you would have no reason to follow God.

Challenging questions

- What does perfect love do with fear, according to 1 John 4:18?
- Why do we love God, according to 1 John 4:19?
- What leads us to repentance, according to Romans 2:4?
- What kind of spirit did I receive: slavery to fear or sonship?
- Is my obedience coming from love or from fear?
- What would following God out of love look like for me?
- Have I experienced God's love, or only heard about His judgment?

Truth summary

> Fear of hell is not the main reason to follow God. I follow Him because He first loved me. His kindness leads me to repentance, and His love compels me. I am not a slave living in fear but a child crying, "Abba! Father!" Perfect love drives out fear.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- **Love, By God**
- **Love, For God**
- **Fear**
- **Obedience**
- **Joy**

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Fear of hell is the main reason to follow God"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Fear of hell is the main reason to follow God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does perfect love do with fear?
- ☐ Why do we love God?
- ☐ What leads us to repentance?
- ☐ Did I receive a spirit of slavery or sonship?
- ☐ Is my obedience from love or fear?
- ☐ Have I experienced God's love?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I love God because He first loved me.
- ☐ Perfect love drives out fear.
- ☐ God's kindness leads me to repentance.
- ☐ Christ's love compels me.
- ☐ I am God's child, not a slave to fear.
- ☐ I can obey God out of love and joy.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **1 John 4:18–19**
  "There is no fear in love, but perfect love drives out fear, because fear involves punishment. The one who fears has not been perfected in love. We love because He first loved us."
- [ ] **Romans 2:4**
  "Or do you disregard the riches of His kindness, tolerance, and patience, not realizing that God's kindness leads you to repentance?"
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 5:14**
  "For Christ's love compels us, because we are convinced that One died for all, therefore all died."
- [ ] **Romans 8:15**
  "For you did not receive a spirit of slavery that returns you to fear, but you received the Spirit of sonship, by whom we cry, 'Abba! Father!'"
- [ ] **John 15:9–11**
  "As the Father has loved Me, so have I loved you. Remain in My love. If you keep My commandments, you will remain in My love, just as I have kept My Father's commandments and remain in His love. I have told you these things so that My joy may be in you and your joy may be complete."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Love log:** Each day, write one way God showed His love to me and one way I responded out of love.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Romans 8:15 becomes: "For **Sarah** did not receive a spirit of slavery that returns **her** to fear, but **she** received the Spirit of sonship, by whom **she** cries, 'Abba! Father!'"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Love, By God" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio download.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write a list of ten ways God has loved you,** and read it before you pray each day.
- ☐ **Do one act of obedience this week** simply because you love God, and notice the difference.
- ☐ **Read Luke 15:11–32,** and write how the father's love differs from fear-based religion.
- ☐ **Pray to God as "Father"** this week, telling Him honestly how that feels.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Fear of hell is the main reason to follow God": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One way I responded to God's love
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Fear of hell is the main reason to follow God.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for loving me first. Help me reject the lie that fear of hell is the main reason to follow You. Let Your perfect love drive out my fear, and let me follow You as Your beloved child, compelled by the love of Christ. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.